

1 and glucose-dependent insulintropic peptide (GIP) hormones produced in the gut for weight loss.

Denmark's Novo Nordisk leads in weight management with Ozempic and Wegovy. Eli Lilly of the US offers Mounjaro. Vivus Pharmaceuticals, also of the US, developed Qsymia, a US-based combination pill that suppresses appetite and boosts metabolism. Switzerland's Roche Pharmaceuticals has orlistat (Xenical), which reduces fat absorption. Orexigen Therapeutics, another US company, has Contrave, a combination pill targeting brain pathways to reduce cravings. But all these cost a bomb.

In India, weight loss options are limited, with orlistat, metformin, and liraglutide (Victoza). Metformin, a diabetes drug, increases insulin sensitivity and lowers blood sugar levels, helping in weight management. Liraglutide, originally a diabetes medication, is prescribed in lower doses for its GLP-1 mimicking effects, aiding in weight loss. Ozempic, introduced in India by Novo Nordisk under the brand name Rybelsus in January 2022 for blood glucose control in adults with Type 2 diabetes, is also prescribed by some doctors for weight loss as it works on the hormones responsible for making you feel hungry.

THE LANDSCAPE

Company	Key drug(s)	2022 revenue* (\$ billion)	Contribution to overall revenue (in %)	Global market share#
● Novo Nordisk	Wegovy, Ozempic	10.20	20	55-60%
● Eli Lilly	Mounjaro	3.20	4.5	25-30%
● Pfizer	Qsymia	0.42	0.2	3-5%
● Boehringer Ingelheim	Saxenda	0.06	0.1	1-2%
● Takeda Pharmaceuticals	Vivantyl	0.06	0.2	1-2%

*REVENUE FROM THE ANTI-OBESITY DRUGS IN 2022; #DATA AS OF OCTOBER 26, 2023 **SOURCE** COMPANY REPORTS, *BT* RESEARCH

Doctors say Wegovy and Mounjaro are also undergoing trials for weight loss in India. "Indian pharma companies can only duplicate them if basic material is available and certainly cannot develop them as yet," says Misra of Fortis.

Several Indian pharma companies are developing their weight-loss drugs, including Dr. Reddy's Laboratories, Zydus Cadila and Sun Pharma. Sun Pharma discovered and is developing GLOO34 (utreglutide), a long-acting GLP-1 receptor agonist (RA) used for non-obese and obese adults without diabetes.

In June this year, Sun Pharma presented data from the first-in-human Phase 1 studies for this molecule. The Phase 1 studies suggest that GLOO34 is a candidate to provide therapeutic benefits for obese adults. Sun Pharma tells *BT* that further clinical studies are planned. "The rising incidence of obesity and diabetes places a significant

burden on global healthcare systems, and GLP-1 agonists have emerged as a useful option for treating these conditions with a single agent," says Dilip Shanghvi, Managing Director, Sun Pharma.

In October 2023, the Subject Expert Committee (SEC) on endocrinology and metabolism gave Dr. Reddy's permission to conduct a bioequivalence study to assess the safety and effectiveness of the drug.

WHEN FAT IS GOOD

The IMARC Group, a market research company, says the Indian weight management market of ₹1,514 crore in 2022 will grow to ₹2,763 crore by 2028. According to Pharmarack, a B2B Indian healthcare management platform, the anti-obesity segment had been growing in single digits since 2019, but the launch of Ozempic in January 2022 was a game changer.

"The market has almost tripled in terms of value and doubled in terms of quantity if one compares the MAT Nov 23 with MAT 21," says Sheetal Sapale, Vice President, Commercial, Pharmarack. MAT, or moving annual total, is the sum of a variable, such as sales figures and production output over the past 12 months.

Vikrant Shrotriya, Corporate Vice President and MD of Novo Nordisk India, tells *BT* that Ozempic is a GLP-1 RA-based therapy for people with Type 2 diabetes and the injectable form is not available in India. But, Rybelsus (Ozempic) tablets, used for treating Type 2 diabetes, are available in India. "We Indians prefer tablets to injectables, and oral semaglutide provides the benefits of the GLP-1 RA therapy with the convenience of a tablet," he says.

Many doctors prescribe GLP-1 receptor agonists such as liraglutide for weight management for diabetics and are thinking of doing so for non-diabetic individuals.

EXERCISE WITH CAUTION

Doctors say India must ensure the safety and efficacy of these medications with robust clinical trials and scrutiny. Most importantly, the government must prevent misuse.

"Some patients choose not to pursue